

Pastry Pirates v3

A UI/UX audit — clearer to play, easier to learn, better on a phone

playpastrypirates.com/3 · audited 2026-08-10 · measured on the real build at 375×812 (the agreed floor) and 390×844, headless Chromium

The five findings that matter most

1. The first 60 seconds have no guided attention — your own playtest pain, and the cheapest fix in this report.
2. Sail squares are ~25px taps that commit instantly, against the 44px standard you set in Phase 19.
3. The forecast chip — the one instrument the game promises is never wrong — renders its text at ~7.5px.
4. Teaching is inverted: the upwind cap is re-taught every single turn, forever; every other rule is taught never.
5. The only rules surface teaches a game that no longer exists: 6-coin treasure (engine pays 5), a ghost needle that was removed, and "plan around the storm" for a storm whose direction you deliberately hid.

Each ranked finding below carries a real-game mock — the shipped screen beside a modified version of the same live page. Everything was measured on the running build, not inferred from source.

What the audit optimizes, in your priority order: a cold new player, on a phone, learning by playing — with full pirate charm everywhere except the moment of action.

What already works — do not touch

An audit that only lists faults would misrepresent this game. These are load-bearing strengths:

The recipe cards are the best screen in the game. Art, hierarchy, flavor-name + plain-name pairing — the pattern the rest of the UI should be pulled toward.

The greyed-button-with-reason pattern (D-41) is genuinely good teaching. The centerpiece recommendation below is that pattern, generalized.

The narration box discipline — top-to-bottom reveal, never-empty, fade-then-replace — is felt. The box reads as a steady narrator, not a flickering log.

The bake-off is player-paced ("Ready to bake!") with big, thumb-sized crates. Its pacing survived phone scale better than any other interaction.

The End of Voyage celebration — pastry art, badges, plain hierarchy — lands. Only its surrounding chrome needs cleanup (finding 12).

How to read the findings

[QUICK] shippable in-place in a day or two · **[MEDIUM]** a real feature, no new systems · **[BIG]** a build you would schedule. Every finding gets the smallest fix that works first; big ideas are clearly marked. Nothing here is sacred — reject freely.

1. Give the first minute a spotlight

[QUICK] · onboarding · your own write-in pain

A cold player's first in-game screen shows five competing surfaces — board, coin, clock, narration box, captains panel — and the one that needs a tap is fourth from the top, below the fold's halfway line. Nothing points at it. You named this yourself: players don't know where to click on the "Ahoy" screen.

Fix (quick): for the first prompt of a voyage only, dim everything except the narration box and let its border glow once. One overlay style, no new systems. The mock is the real page with exactly that applied.

And rename the button. "Arrgh!" is charm with no function — your own rule is charm never on actions. "Arrgh! Set sail →" keeps the voice and tells the thumb what happens next.

Fix (medium): a 3-beat intro in the same box (goal → yer recipe → "watch this panel — she'll steer ye straight!"), each beat one tap. Your v1 intro copy already did this; v3 dropped it.



BEFORE — shipped v3



AFTER — proposed

2. Sail taps: ~25px targets that commit a whole turn

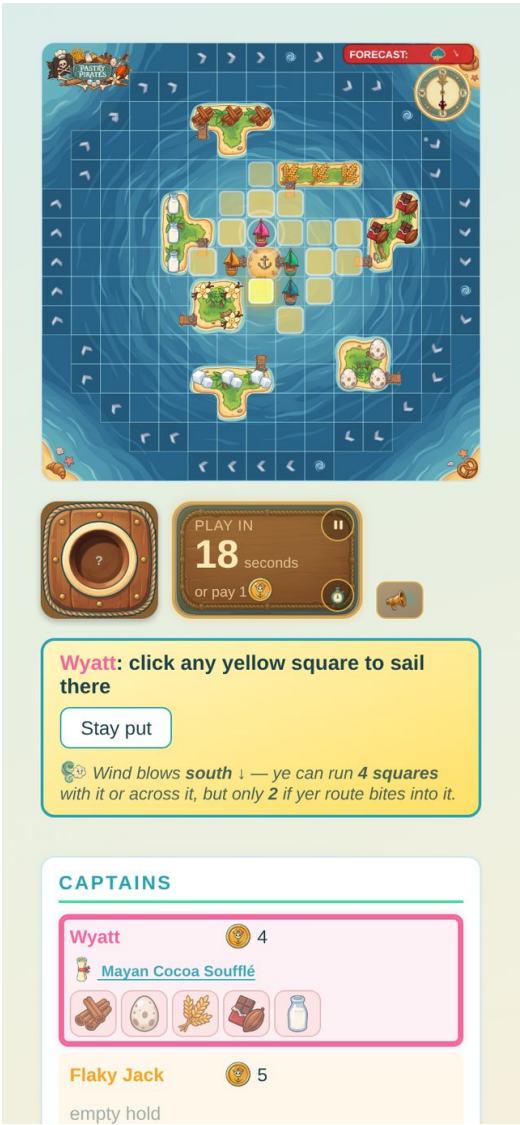
[QUICK]+[MEDIUM] · core loop · mobile

At 375px the board renders 319px wide; 13 columns make each sail square a **~25px tap target** — your own Phase-19 standard is 44px. The highlight squares sit at 50% opacity, and the only hover affordances are dead on touch. One mis-tap spends the turn: movement is the whole strategy, and there is no undo.

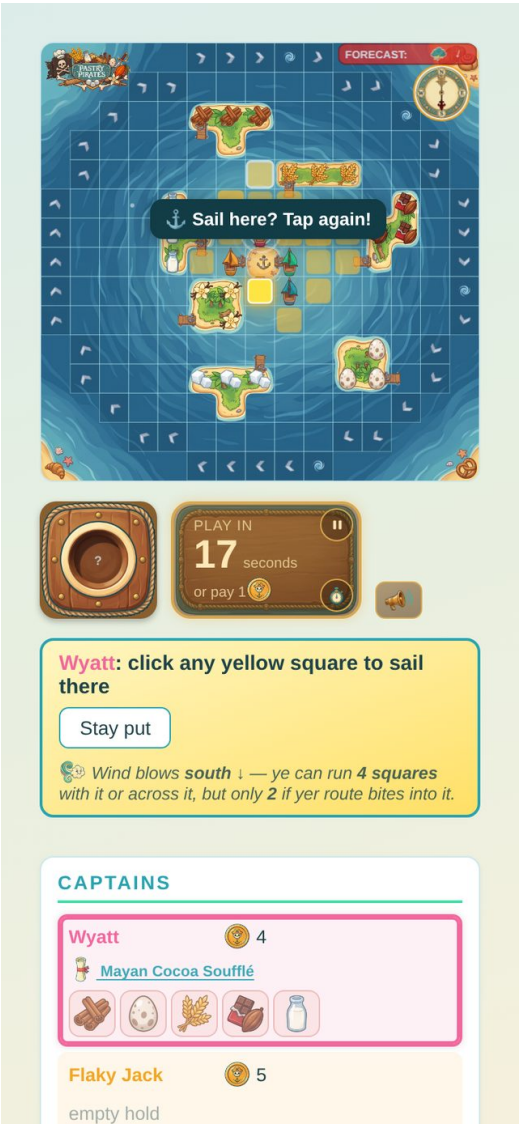
Fix (quick): a contrast pass — brighter fill, white stroke, higher opacity (left mock).

Fix (medium, recommended): two-tap with a ghost ship. First tap previews: yer boat's ghost appears on the square (you already approved ghost-boat previews for the rim arcs) and a confirm chip appears. Second tap commits; tapping elsewhere moves the ghost. The effective target becomes the whole board, and mis-taps cost nothing (right mock).

Fix (big): edge-to-edge board under 480px — dropping the side gutters takes the board from 319px to 375px (+18% linear, ~29px cells). Pairs with, not replaces, the two-tap.



AFTER (quick) — contrast pass



AFTER (medium) — ghost-ship two-tap

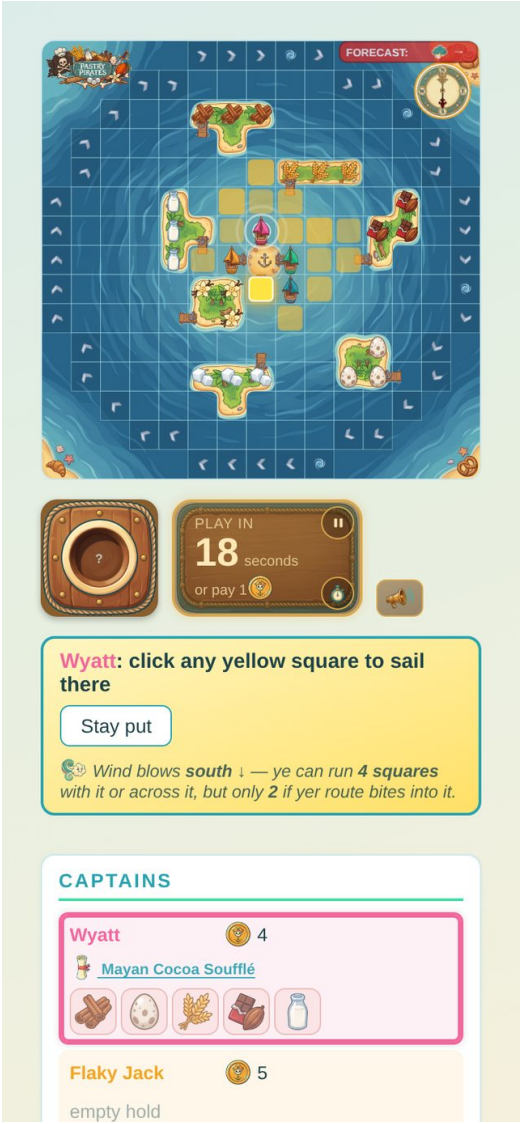
3. The instruments are illegible: 7.5px forecast text

[QUICK] · board readability

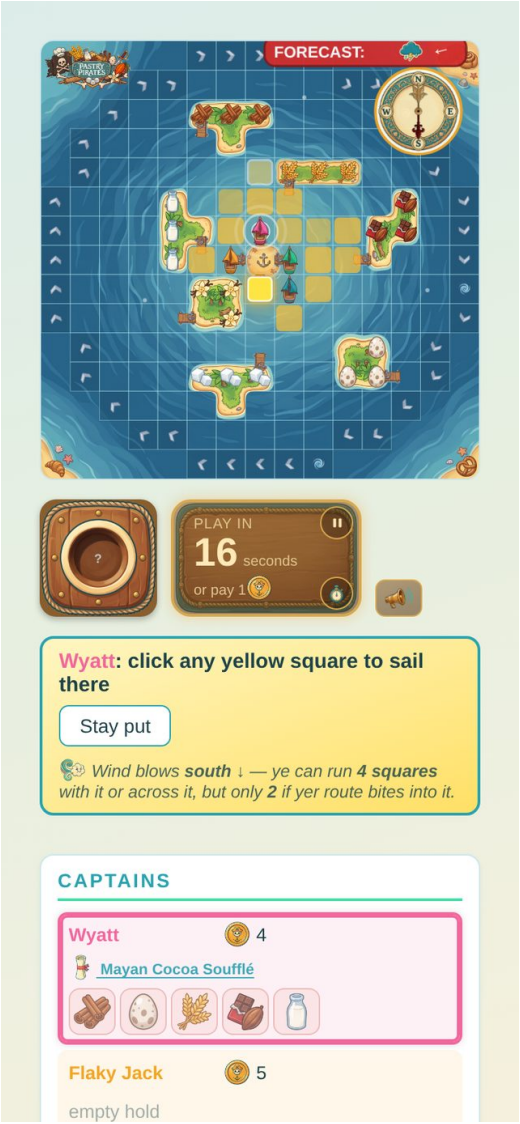
The board SVG is 640 units wide, so at 375px one unit is ~0.5px. The FORECAST chip's label renders at ~7.5px; the hidden-storm spinner at ~9px; the compass letters smaller still; the rim chevrons are pale grey on mid-blue. This is the instrument cluster the whole wind system depends on — the forecast is designed to be "never wrong," and it's the least legible thing on the screen. You picked "reading the board" as a top phone pain.

Fix (quick): scale the compass+chip HUD group ~1.5× under 480px and nudge it into the board corner (one SVG transform — the mock is the real page with exactly that). Recolor rim chevrons white-on-dark.

The mock happened to catch a storm warning: compare how the red chip reads at the two sizes.



BEFORE — chip text ~7.5px



AFTER — HUD x1.55, storm red readable

4. Teach-in-play: the centerpiece

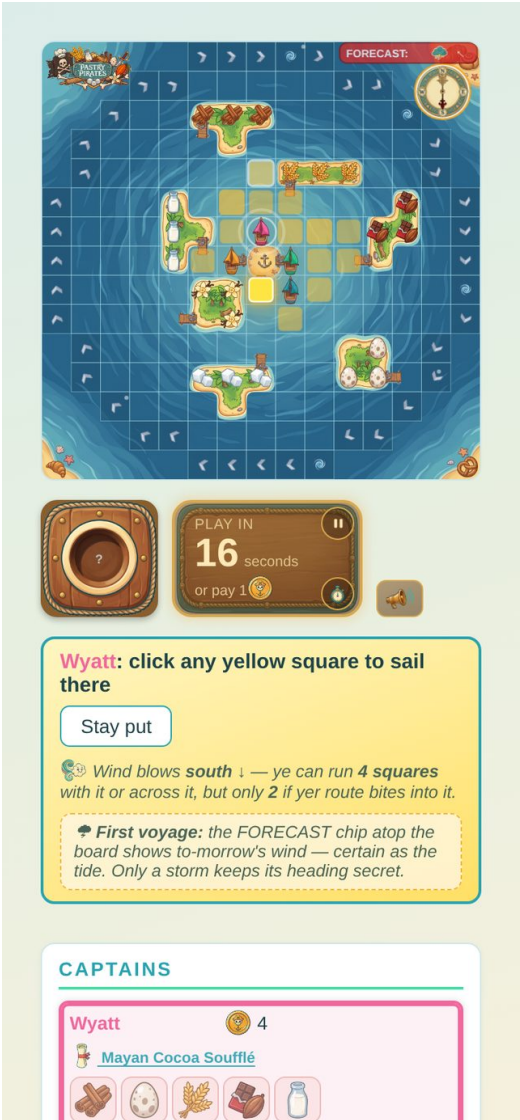
[MEDIUM] · learnability · your chosen shape

Live capture corrected my assumption here: the game DOES teach the upwind cap — **every turn, forever**, in the sail prompt's helper line ("...only 2 if yer route bites into it"). And that line says **"click any yellow square"** on a touch device. Meanwhile every other rule is taught never: the coin that IS the flip button (it gains a FLIP face and the plank glows, but nothing says TAP it — this stalled three of my automation drivers, and a thumb has it worse), the forecast chip, the hidden storm heading, rising crate prices, battle calls, the trade window, the rim current.

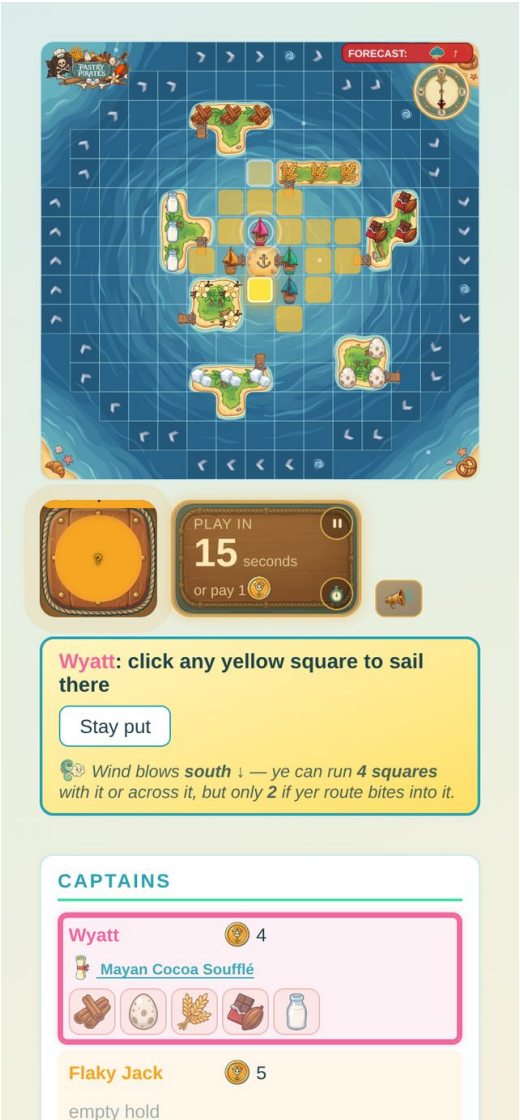
So the teaching is inverted: one rule is over-taught into noise; the rest are silent. The shape you picked fixes both at once:

A first-voyage hint ledger. ~8 one-line hints in the game's voice, each fired the first time its mechanic appears, shown in the existing italic helper slot (reveal order stays settled), each shown once, all retired after voyage one (stored beside pp3_* saves). The standing upwind line retires with them — by voyage three the panel goes quiet and the charm does the talking.

Two live mocks: a forecast hint in the helper slot, and the flip-coin ribbon — shown until the player's first-ever tap, because a control that only glows does not read as a button to a cold player.



AFTER — first-voyage hint, helper slot



AFTER — "tap the coin" ribbon

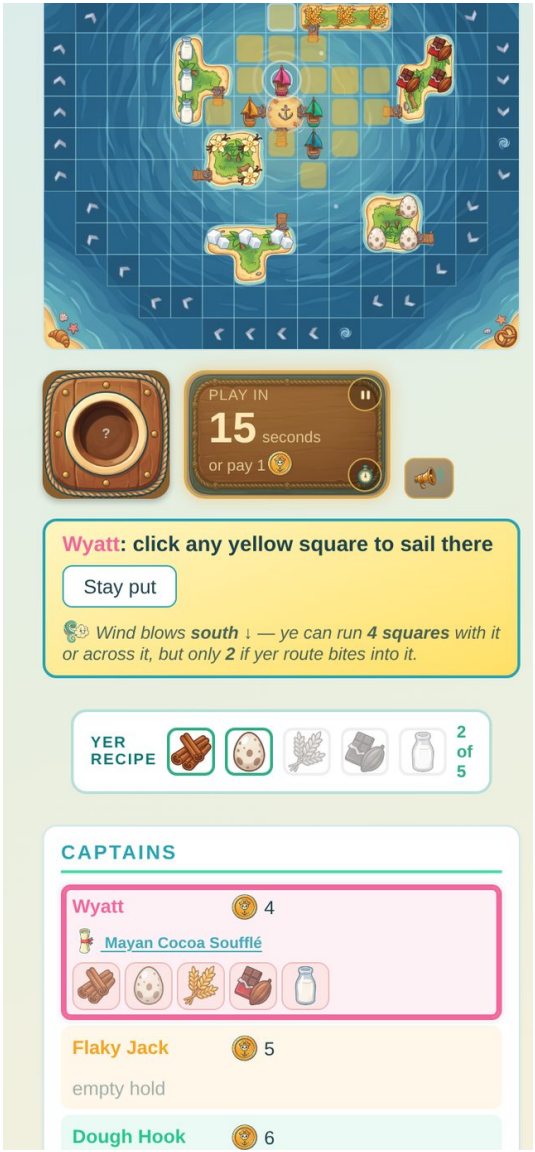
5. Yer recipe is invisible while ye decide

[QUICK]+[MEDIUM] · scrolling to see state

Deciding where to sail needs the board (top of page) and your remaining ingredients (bottom, in the captains panel — at or below the fold at both 375×812 and 390×844). The active-captain-to-top re-sort you shipped exists **in pass-and-play only**; solo keeps seat order, so YOUR row can sit last.

Fix (quick): port the re-sort to solo. One condition.

Fix (medium, mocked): a one-row hold strip pinned between the clock row and the narration box: yer five recipe chips, greyed until collected, "2 of 5" at the end, tap to open the recipe card. ~50px of height buys the whole decision loop on one screen.



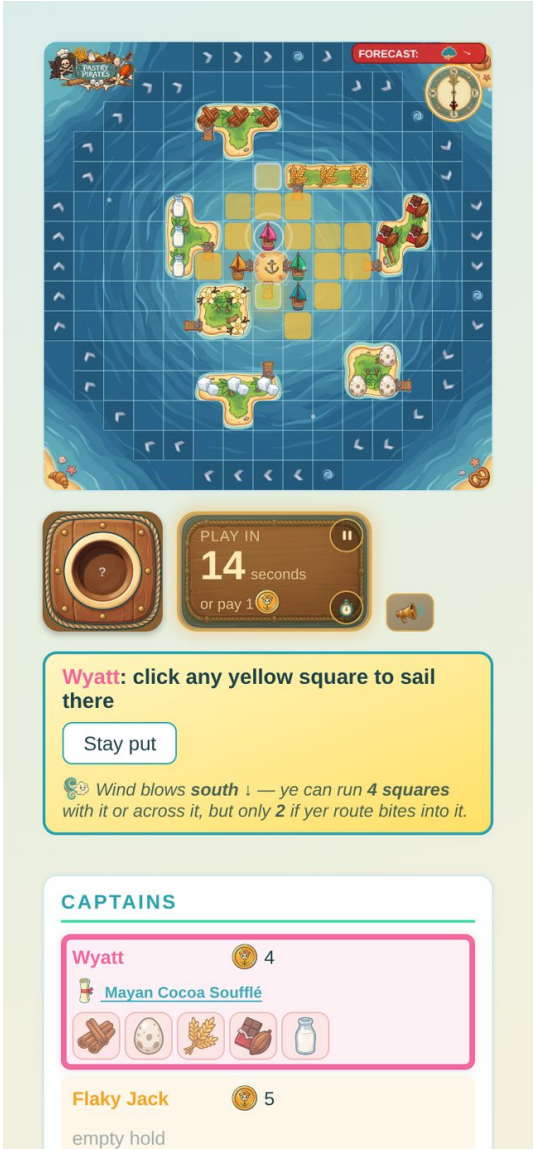
AFTER — pinned hold strip (real page, injected)

6. The clock pressures the player who is still learning

[QUICK] · solo onboarding

Solo runs "PLAY IN 20 seconds — or pay 1 coin" from the very first turn (the mocks caught it at 17 and 16 while I composed screenshots). A cold player is fined for reading. Your own todo notes solo is also the one mode missing the clock toggle.

Fix (quick): solo defaults to no clock, toggle present; the first voyage on a device is always clockless. Multiplayer keeps its shot clock untouched (lockstep intact).



AFTER — practice voyage, no clock (real page)

7. The rules modal teaches a game that no longer exists

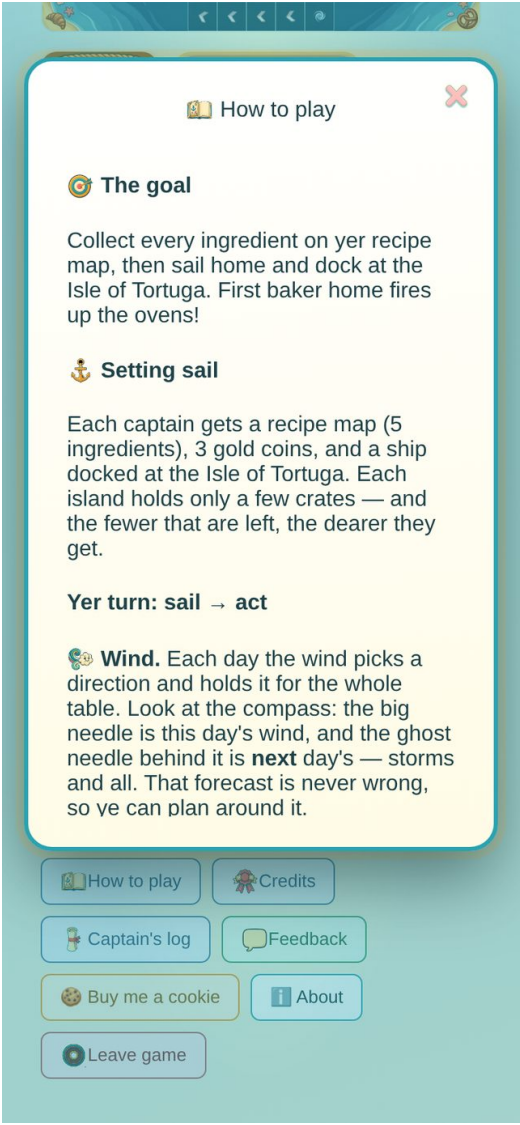
[QUICK] copy + [MEDIUM] structure

The how-to-play modal is the game's only rules surface, and at 375px it is **5.3 screens** of scrolling prose (2,567px in a 487px window). Worse, it has drifted from the shipped engine in three places:

- It teaches **6 coins** for heads at a dock — the engine pays **5** (dockHeads:5).
- It teaches "the **ghost needle** behind it is next day's" — you rejected and removed the ghost needle; the forecast is the chip.
- It promises storms can be planned around ("that forecast is never wrong... a storm is never a surprise") — the storm's heading is **deliberately hidden**, your design decision, and the copy contradicts it.

Fix (quick): correct the three facts. Same day, ship it.

Fix (medium, mocked): restructure into six swipeable illustrated cards — goal / sail / dock / battle / trade / storm — each one screen, each led by the game's own art. Keep the full prose behind a "spin the long yarn" link for the readers.



BEFORE — screen 1 of 5.3



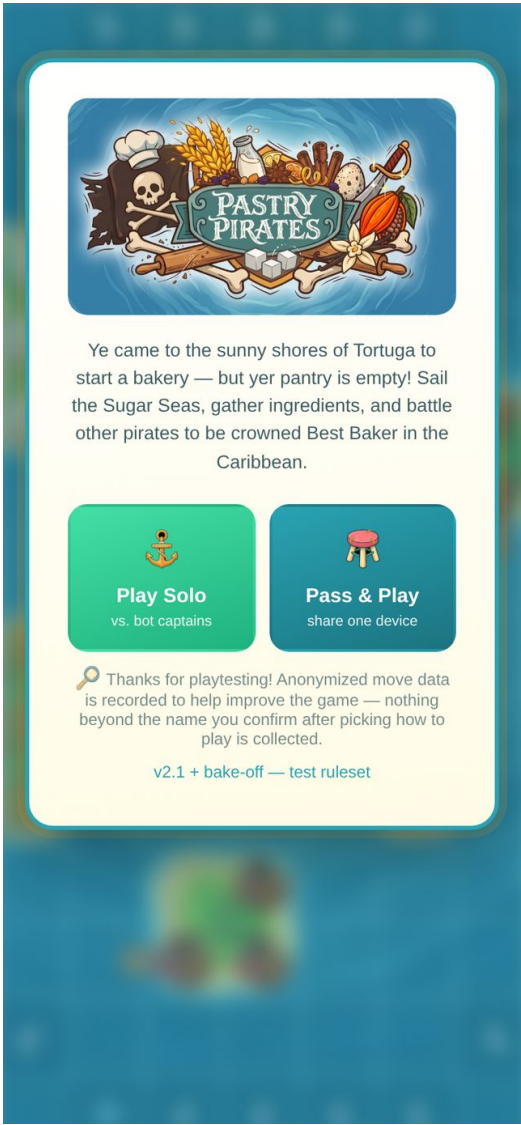
AFTER — card 2 of 6, one screen

8. The welcome screen has no path to the rules

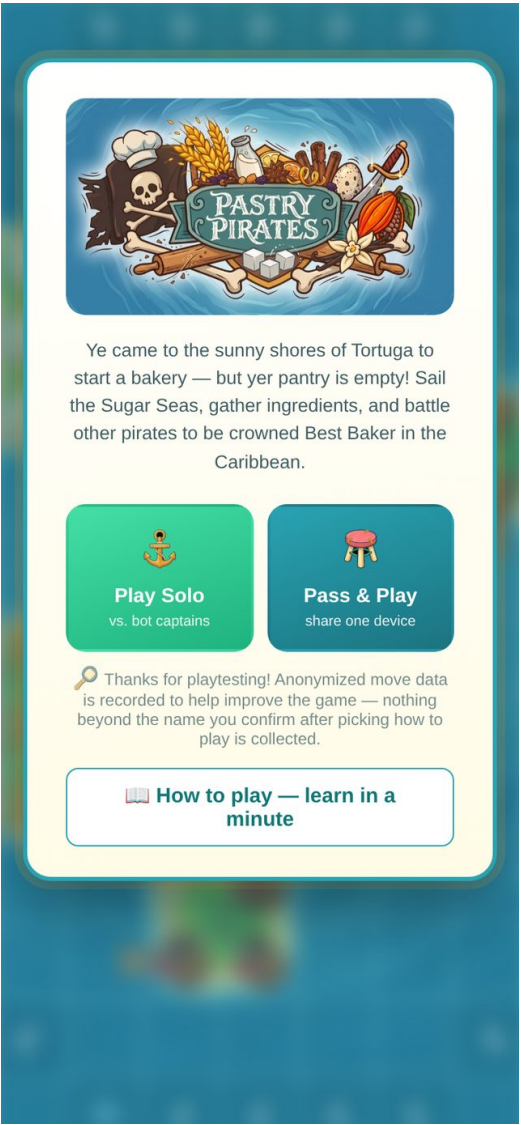
[QUICK] · first run

Before starting a game there is **no way to learn anything**: the only actions are the two mode cards. (In-game, How-to-play lives in the footer — below the fold.) The front door also speaks dev: "v2.1 + bake-off — test ruleset" and four lines of telemetry prose.

Fix (quick, mocked): a "How to play — learn in a minute" link under the cards (opening the finding-7 cards); telemetry compressed to one line with a tap-to-expand; version string moved to About. The playtest transparency stays — it just stops being the third-loudest thing on the page.



BEFORE — shipped v3



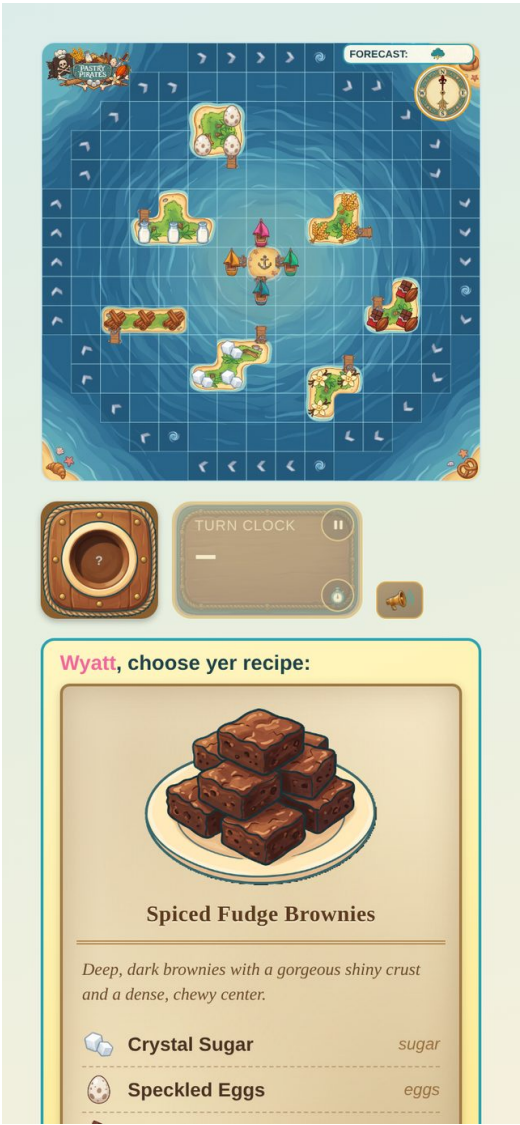
AFTER — proposed

9. Recipe choice: compared by scrolling, chosen blind

[MEDIUM] · first run

The recipe cards are the best-crafted surface in the game — and at 375px they are 423px tall each, so the two choices are **never both on screen**; players compare by memory. And nothing connects a recipe to the BOARD: which islands hold its ingredients, how far they are. The first meaningful decision is made blind.

Fix (mocked): compact compare — both cards fit one screen (drop the description line, it returns on the recipe card later) — and when a card is focused, the docks holding its five ingredients glow on the board above. The choice becomes the tutorial: it teaches island-ingredient mapping before the first sail.



BEFORE — card 1 of 2, 423px each



AFTER — compare + dock glow

10. Chrome tap targets bottom out at 24px

[QUICK] · mobile ergonomics

The ≤480px stylesheet — the block whose own comment says controls "read as too small to tap accurately" and bumps everything ~1.5× — leaves the clock's pause and timer toggles at **24×24px**. Your standard is 44px. The mute button and the 11px recipe-name link in the captains panel are in the same family.

Fix (quick): a 44px minimum hit area via padding on every interactive control — no visual redesign, the artwork stays exactly as drawn. Make the whole captains row open the recipe card, not just the 11px link.

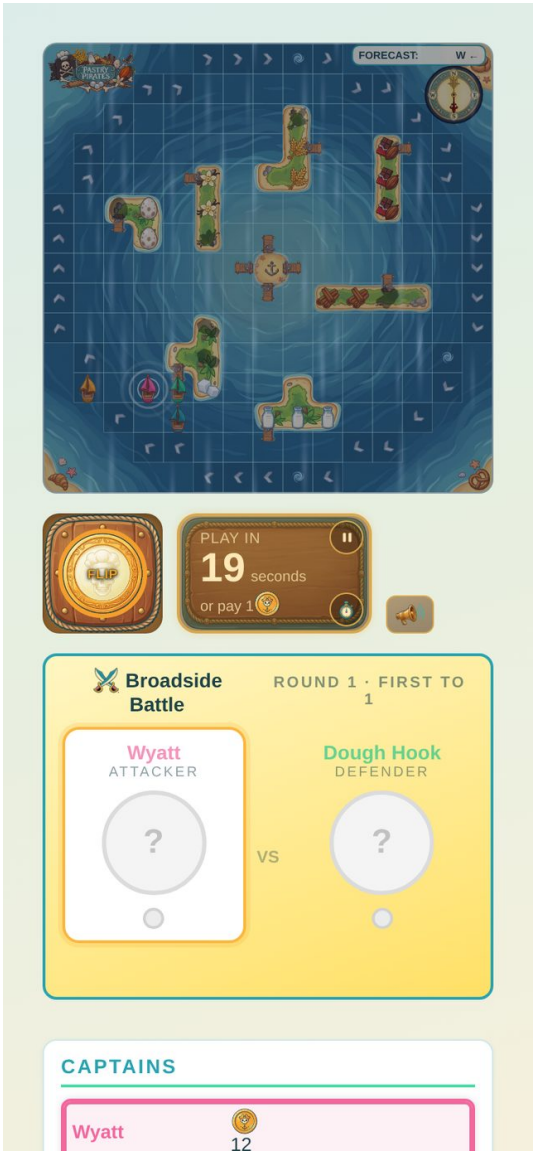
11. Mid-turn prompts: good bones, four specifics

[QUICK] copy · in-play clarity

The prompt machinery is sound: amounts live on buttons, disabled actions carry reasons, and the Broadside Battle panel (captured live, below) has real hierarchy — attacker/defender cards, round counter, the works. Four specifics still tax a new player:

- The sail helper says **"click"**; every surface should say **tap** on touch (or drop the verb: "any yellow square be in reach").
- **The turn clock keeps counting through a battle** — "PLAY IN 19s — or pay 1" while the flip panel waits. A fight is the game's most rule-dense moment; pause the clock (or hide it) inside battles.
- "ROUND 1 · FIRST TO 1" wraps its final digit onto its own line at 375px — your no-orphaned-units rule.
- The bake-off's helper ("Study the order. Start the shuffle when yer ready.") persists unchanged into the covered-crates phase — a stale instruction at the moment of highest tension. Swap it on phase change: "Tap the crates in recipe order!"

"Downwind," "counter," and the call side-bet still get their first-time framing from the finding-4 hint ledger — one line each, once.



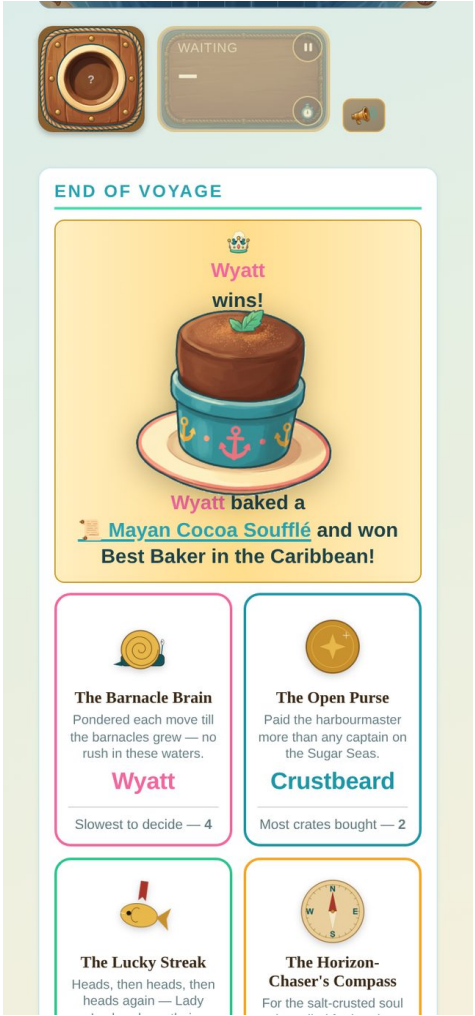
LIVE — battle panel, clock still running above it

12. End of Voyage: dead chrome above the celebration

[QUICK] · polish

The winner card, pastry art, and badges land beautifully — but a ghosted flip coin and a frozen "WAITING" turn clock sit directly above "END OF VOYAGE," and the celebration starts below the fold because of them.

Fix (quick): hide the flip/clock row when the stats panel shows. One style rule.



BEFORE — coin + WAITING clock above the celebration

The full catalog

Everything found, including what didn't make the ranked list. QUICK unless noted.

- C1.** The name modal's **X** confirms the shown name instead of cancelling. Your own P10 ruling: close means cancel. If dismissal-confirms is intentional here, swap the glyph for a ✓ so the control tells the truth.
- C2.** The how-to-play modal doesn't close on Escape (measured). Check backdrop-tap too. Small, but modals that don't release trap phone users hardest.
- C3.** Hover affordances (.sailCell: hover, button hovers) have no touch equivalent — every hover-only signal is invisible to the primary device. Audit sweep: any state carried only by :hover gets a touch twin.
- C4.** Chat bubbles on the board: 12px text, 42% max width. Fine as flavor; if bots ever say anything mechanical, it's below the readability floor.
- C5.** Captains rows are 13.5px with the recipe link at 11px — the primary state surface runs 2–4px below everything else. One size step up costs ~14px of height per row.
- C6.** Bake-off: the step list scrolls off-screen while tapping crates at 375px. Pin a one-line reminder ("order: ■→■→...") above the crate row during the guess phase — or accept it as memory challenge by design; then it's a ruling, not an accident.
- C7.** reduced-motion kills the sail-square bounce, leaving 50%-opacity tint as the ONLY reachable-square signal. Pair the finding-2 contrast pass with a reduced-motion check.
- C8.** Footer: seven buttons in a wrap grid; the amber "Buy me a cookie" outshouts "How to play." Order by player need: How to play / Recipe / Log / Feedback / About / Credits / cookie last (it will read fine there — generosity doesn't need volume).
- C9.** The welcome screen still renders the live blurred game behind it — your standing perf todo (static pre-blurred image + background asset load) stands; heat is UX on the device the game targets.
- C10.** Storm round: the round header carries the storm, but the board's storm overlay at 375px reads as a subtle tint — consider one full-board flash frame (motion-safe) so the shove has a cause on screen. [MEDIUM]
- C11.** The turn clock's pause + hourglass icon buttons have no labels and no pressed feedback — the multiplayer version of this cost you rounds in playtests (your todo: "give visual feedback that it has been clicked"). Same fix here.
- C12.** Version/telemetry strings sit on an in-world surface in out-of-world voice. Your diegetic boundary says they belong on About (out-of-world) — finding 8 moves them.
- C13.** Bots teach by playing: the race planner treats the rim as never worth staging, so the game's least discoverable mechanic (free rim travel) is now demonstrated by nobody. Consider letting a trailing bot showboat the rim when it costs nothing — your original "demonstrability, not win rate" intent. [MEDIUM]
- C14.** Pass-and-play was not deep-audited this pass (solo was the cold-player path). The hand-off overlay and shared-intro flow deserve their own 30 minutes on a real device.
- C15.** RULES-V2.md and the modal disagree with the engine on dock treasure (both say 6; engine pays 5). Whichever is right, make the other two match — a spec that disagrees with its build converts every future reader into a bug reporter.

Measurements ledger

- 375×812 (floor): board 319px → 24.5px cells; sail highlight ~22px visual after inset.
- 390×844: board 334px → 25.7px cells; action panel top 479px; captains panel 600–845px (bottom under the fold); footer 899px (below fold); page 1091px tall.
- Forecast chip: 190×28 SVG units → ~95×14px at 375; label 15u ≈ 7.5px; storm spinner 18u ≈ 9px.
- How-to-play: 3,888 characters; 2,567px scroll in a 487px window = 5.3 screens; Escape does not close it.
- Recipe choice: two cards, 423×291px each, stacked.
- Recipe cards vs engine: modal says heads pays 6 coins; engine dockHeads = 5.
- ≤480px block: #scPause / #scTimerToggle 24×24px; flip coin clamp(54px...96px); Phase-19 standard 44px.
- Type: narration 15px; helper 12.5px italic; captains rows 13.5px; recipe link 11px; chat bubbles 12px.
- Solo clock: "PLAY IN 20 seconds — or pay 1 coin" from turn 1; no toggle in solo.

Method & honest limits

Every number above was measured on the running v3 build (local serve of the repo at the audited commit), driven end-to-end at phone scale — welcome through recipe choice, sailing, storms, the bake-off, and End of Voyage. Mocks are the same live pages with styles/DOM injected, screenshotted — not drawings.

Limits: measurements are headless Chromium, not Safari — layout numbers transfer, rendering feel needs your phone pass (private tab, fresh port). End of Voyage was reached via the project's standard recipe-injection practice. Dock/trade/battle prompts were exercised less than sail/bake flows in the driven runs; finding 11 leans partly on the prompt code and your recorded playtest history for those flows. Multiplayer and pass-and-play were out of scope (C14).

Suggested order of work

Week of quick wins: 1 (spotlight + button), 3 (HUD scale), 6 (solo clock), 7-copy (three facts), 8 (welcome link), 10 (44px sweep), 12 (EoV chrome), 11-copy (tap/stale helper).

The build worth scheduling: 4 (hint ledger) + 2 (ghost two-tap) — together they are the cold-player experience. Then 5 (hold strip), 9 (recipe compare), 7 (cards).

Big-ticket, your call: edge-to-edge board; the deferred guided first voyage (the hint ledger may make it unnecessary — ship hints first, watch one cold playtester, then decide).